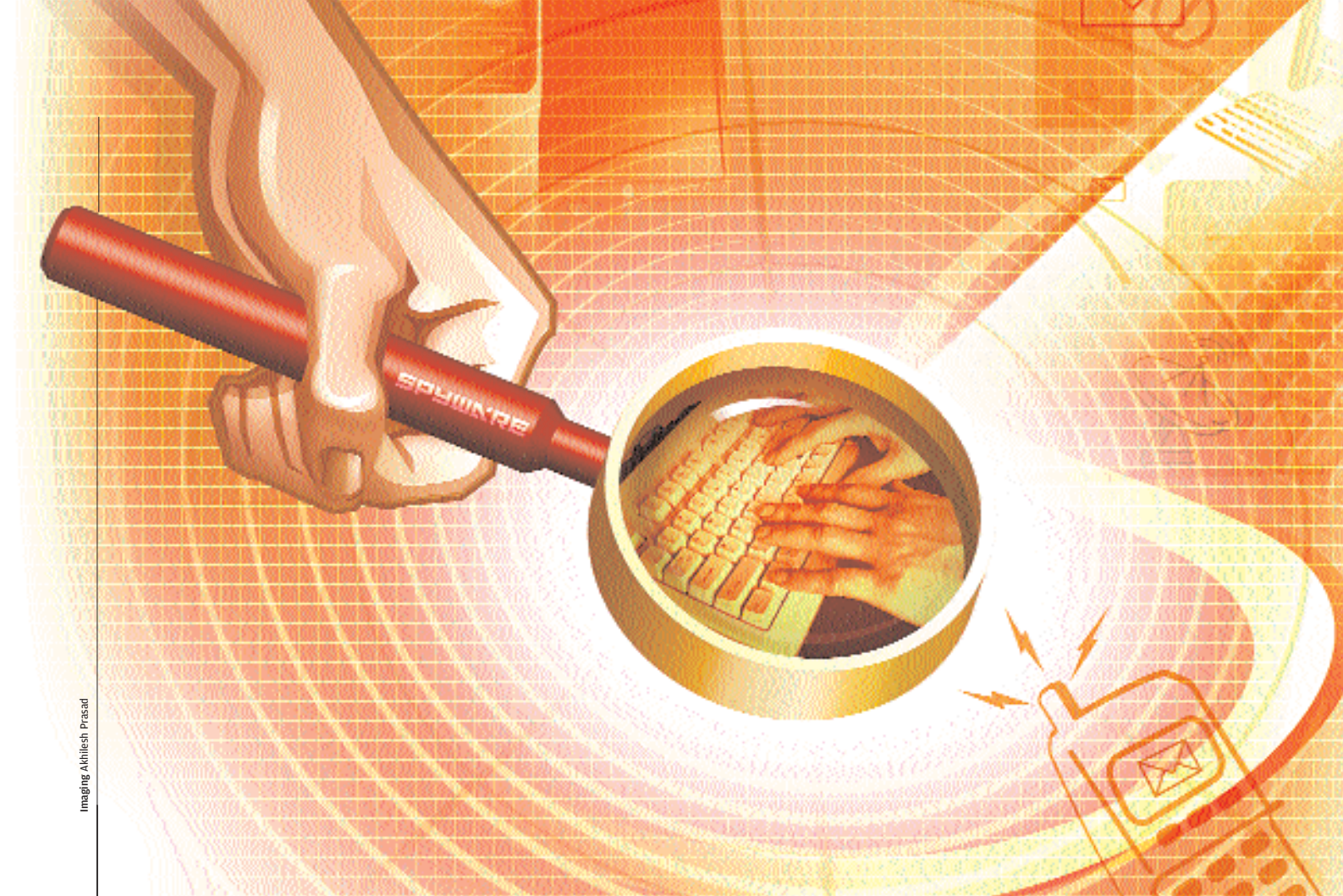




The Ace Spy Guy

A young collegian from Jaipur does India proud with his numerous spy software creations, the most popular being AceSpy

Renuka Rane

How many 21-year-olds in India own a profit-making enterprise in the US? Meet Zeeshan Alam, a third-year student of computer engineering at the National Institute of Technology, Jaipur. Alam is the co-owner of Retina-X Studios (www.retinax.com), and his partner is US-based James Johns. Alam has independently created spy software—AceSpy.

Starting Out

A lover of all things tech, Alam decided to take up computers full-time. In 2004, he completed the Microsoft Student Project Programme where he created a state employment portal. Alam also won several software designing awards.

The enterprising Alam says, “The idea of developing spy software occurred to me in mid-2002. It was a time when the issues of Internet romance, online chatting and pornography appeared regularly in newspapers. My dad too had a growing concern about me spending a lot of time online, and was worried if I was addicted to the above elements.

“It was then that I had an idea: what if I could record the goings-on on the desktop, like a movie, at regular intervals in stealth mode, where the software would not be visible in the Task Manager’s Processes or Applications and would also not be detected by other users? All actions could be viewed later to reveal what other users do on your PC in your absence.”

A Few Hits At First

This thought took form and resulted in Alam’s first spy software creation—Sys Detective+. In time, Alam added more features including key logging, Web capture, e-mail and SMS alerts, Web content blocking and others.

Once Alam realised he had the recipe for a successful software, he submitted Sys Detective+ to many shareware sites and also made a site exclusively for it using Regsoft, an e-commerce processing service, to take care of the transactions, if any. Alam even put a small classified ad in *The Times of India*.

All this took place around the end of 2002. Barring a few sales here and there, Alam did not, unfortunately, receive much of a response for Sys Detective+. But in March 2003, he came